





free will  
and  
determinism

against  
compatibilist  
free will

A red circular button with a slight drop shadow, containing the text "against incompatibilist free will" in white, lowercase, sans-serif font.

against  
incompatibilist  
free will

This argument seems to show that the combination of four theses — that No one has any choice about the past, no choice about the laws of nature, the no choice principle, and determinism — rules out free will.

Since the first three of these theses seem quite plausible, the argument seems to show that if determinism is true, there are no free actions — and hence that free will is incompatible with determinism.

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
  2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
- 

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will



Real/|the master argument:

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe in free will, and find the consequence argument persuasive, it looks tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

But, we'll see now, this argument can also be given a plausible defense.

One way to introduce this defense is with the following quote from

David Hume:

Hume's basic thought is that there is a big difference between free actions and actions which are random or chance.

Here's a thought experiment:

Now ask yourself: is Alex's choice free? It seems very clear that it is not. It is undetermined by facts prior to the relevant run of the Randomizer, but it is random. It is not up to Alex what he does; and free actions have to be up to the person doing the action.

This suggests:



But now consider the idea that free will requires the falsity of determinism. If this is true, then it must be that free actions (or their immediate causes) are undetermined:

But consider what an undetermined act would be. It would be an action which is such that the entire history of the universe up to that point is consistent with the act either happening or not happening. So if the act happens, nothing **makes** it happen. In particular, nothing that the person who does the action, or anyone else, does makes the action happen.

One way to state the conclusion of the control argument is that free will  
requires determinism.

1. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are undetermined.
  2. If an action is undetermined, then it is random.
  3. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are random. (1,2)
  4. No random acts are free.
- 

C. If Libertarianism is true, then there are no free actions.

# The control argument

But this is very bad news for free will if you found the consequence argument convincing. For that argument seems to show that free will is **incompatible** with determinism.

And if free will both requires determinism and is incompatible with it,  
then the very idea of free will seems to be contradictory. If this is right,  
then the idea of a free action is like the idea of a married bachelor.

The problem is that our idea of free action seems to require that those actions be both undetermined and under our control. The master argument is based on the idea that no action could have both of these features.



But: it really does seem like we have free will! If you agree with that, then  
it seems that this is not a belief which we should give up easily.

Then the question to ask yourself is whether you think that the consequence argument or the control argument is more likely to have a flaw — and what that flaw might be.

1. Either (i) Compatibilism is true or (ii) Libertarianism is true or (iii) there is no free will.
2. Compatibilism is false.
3. Libertarianism is false.

-----

C. There is no free will.

# THE MASTER ARGUMENT AGAINST THE REALITY OF FREE WILL



theorie about the fact that if DNR

future is not inconsistent with the state of the

1. No one has any choice about events which



varlatatie + the last of the

of interest.

5. No one has any choice about what the laws

6. If  $\det A$  is true, then  $A$  has any

then DECISION. (4,5)



happened in the distant past.

C. If  $\text{determinist}$  is true, then  $\text{no one has any}$



3. If determined, the only one

then DECISION happens. (3)

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

4. If determinism is true, the laws of

2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

~ If none has about choice about whether P,

and none has any choice about whether,

if  $P$ , then  $Q$ , then one has any choice



about whether @.



choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

combination of four - that No

This argument seems to show that the

rules out free will.

choice about the laws of nature, then no

one has any choice about the past, no



choice principle, and determinism

hence that free will is incompatible with

true, there are no free actions — and

Since the first three of these theses

dearminism.

seem quite plausible, the argument

seems to show that if determinism is









The master argument against the reality of free will

tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe

in free will, and find the consequent argument persuasive, it looks

defenses.

But, we'll see now, this argument can also be given a plausible



One way to introduce this defense is with the following quote from

David Hume:

Human's basic thought is that there is a big difference between free

actions and actions which are not chance.

Randomizer, but it is random. It is not up to Alex what he does; and

not. It is undetermined by facts prior to the relevant run of the

Now ask yourself: is Alex's choice free? It seems very clear that it is

freedoms have to be up to the person doing the action.



But now consider the idea that free will requires the falsity of

determinism. If this is true, then it must be that free actions (or their

immediate cause) are undetermined:



But consider what an understatement it would be

happen. In particular, nothing that persons who do the

up to that point is consistent with the act either happening or

not happening. So if the act happens, nothing makes it

an action which is such that the entire history of the universe



action, or anyone else, does make the action happen.

requires determinism.

One way to state the conclusion of the entire argument is that free will



3. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there

4. Norms are free.

C. If Libertarianism is true, there are

underrinded.





2. If  $a$  and  $a'$  are undetermined, then it is

are free actions, those actions are

raindonin.

no free actors.

1. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there

raindrops. (1,2)







But this is very bad news for free will if you found the consequence

argument convincing. For that argument to show that free will is

incompatible with determinism.

And if free will both requires determinism and is incompatible with it,

then the idea of a free action is like the idea of a married bachelor.

then the very idea of free will seems to be contradictory. If this is right,

argument is based on the idea that no action could have both of these



The problem is that our idea of free actions requires that the

features.



action is better than inaction

The master

But: it really does seem like we have free will! If you agree with that, then

it seems that this is not a belief which we should give up easily.

flaw— and what that flaw might be.

consequence argument the control argument is more likely to have a

Then the question to ask yourself is whether you think that the





3:Libertarianism is false.



Libertarianism is true or (iii) there is no free

W i i i .

1. Either  $(i) \text{Compat} i b i 1$  is true or  $(i i)$

2. compatibilism is false.

C. Their is no fire in will.







reality of free will.

We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the

Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

for (2), and one for (3).



Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2)

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "against compatibilist free will" is written in white, bold, lowercase letters, arranged in three lines.

**against  
compatibilist  
free will**

against  
incompatibilist  
free will

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
  2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
- 

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will



Wili.

0: There is no fire in.





2. If Libertarianism is true, there is no free

1. Freewill is incompatible with determinism.



